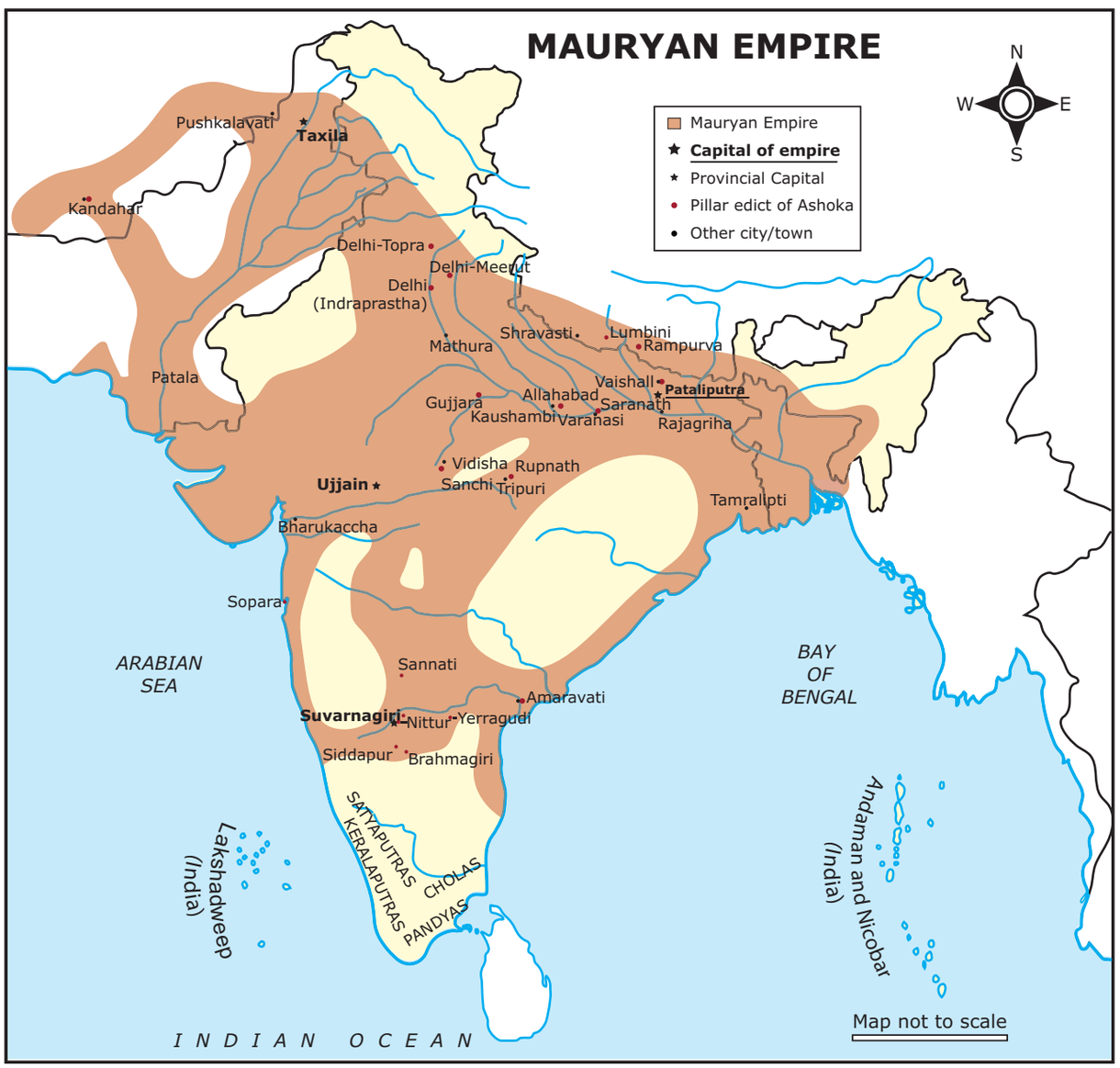
If we multiply this by the number of infantry and cavalry, we get an idea of the enormous resources needed to maintain the army and the administrative staff.

Arthasastra

Perhaps the most detailed account of the administration is to be found in the *Arthasastra* (though the work itself is now dated to a few centuries later). However, it must be remembered that the *Arthasastra* was a prescriptive text, which laid down the guidelines for good administration. If we add to this the information from Ashoka's edicts and the work of Megasthenes, we get a more comprehensive picture of the Mauryan state as it was.

Provincial Administration

At the head of the administration was the king. He was assisted by a council of ministers and a *purohita* or priest, who was a person of great importance, and secretaries known as *mahamatriyas*. The capital region of Pataliputra was directly administered. The rest of the empire was divided into four provinces based at Suvarnagiri (near Kurnool in Andhra Pradesh), Ujjain (Avanti, Malwa), Taxila in the north-west, and Tosali in Odisha in the south-east. The provinces were administered by governors who were usually royal princes. In each region,



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